

Tabula: Getting Data from PDFs

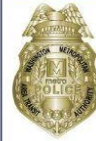
...

I hate PDFs and so should you.

Data Jail

Download this file:

<https://www.wmata.com/content/dam/wmata-com/about/transit-police/may2026-blotters/Blotter-June-19-2026.pdf>



MetroTransit Police Bus - Rail - Parking Lot - Metro Facilities - Others Metro Transit Police Blotter



For : Monday, June 17, 2024

Date	Time	Disposition	Location	Rail Station	Call Type	Disposition Comments
06/17/2024	03:16:00	REPORT	1911 Southern Ave	SOAV	ROBBERY ARMED	ARMED ROBBERY
06/17/2024	07:05:00	ARREST	650 Maryland Ave SW	-	FOLLOW UP	WARRANT SERVICE / RECOVERED GUN
06/17/2024	07:09:00	REPORT	5250 Wisconsin Ave NW (jennifer St Elevator)	FRHE	THEFT	THEFT
06/17/2024	07:34:00	REPORT	730 Kenilworth Ave Ne(295 Side)	MINA	SUBJ WWEAPON	THREATS
06/17/2024	07:43:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	625 9th St NW	GALP	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/17/2024	08:06:00	REPORT	4704 Old Soper Rd	BRAV	TRAFFIC STOP	DRIVING ON SUSP LICENSE
06/17/2024	08:27:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	4704 Old Soper Rd	BRAV	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/17/2024	08:32:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	4201 Ellin Rd	NEWG	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/17/2024	08:38:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	4704 Old Soper Rd	BRAV	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/17/2024	08:44:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	4704 Old Soper Rd	BRAV	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/17/2024	08:51:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	1101 Howard Rd SE (garage Side)	ANAC	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/17/2024	08:52:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	1101 Howard Rd SE (garage Side)	ANAC	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/17/2024	08:54:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	4201 Ellin Rd	NEWG	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/17/2024	08:55:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	4704 Old Soper Rd	BRAV	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/17/2024	09:06:00	REPORT	5250 Wisconsin Ave NW (jennifer St Elevator)	FRHE	ASSIST PATRON	HARASSMENT
06/17/2024	09:08:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	1101 Howard Rd SE (garage Side)	ANAC	SUBJECT STOP	FTP

The goal: get tabular data out of a PDF

PDFs often have data that we can use to make comparisons. For example, the tables in this document.

If we had this as data, we could ask some more questions of it: what kinds of calls at which locations, for instance.

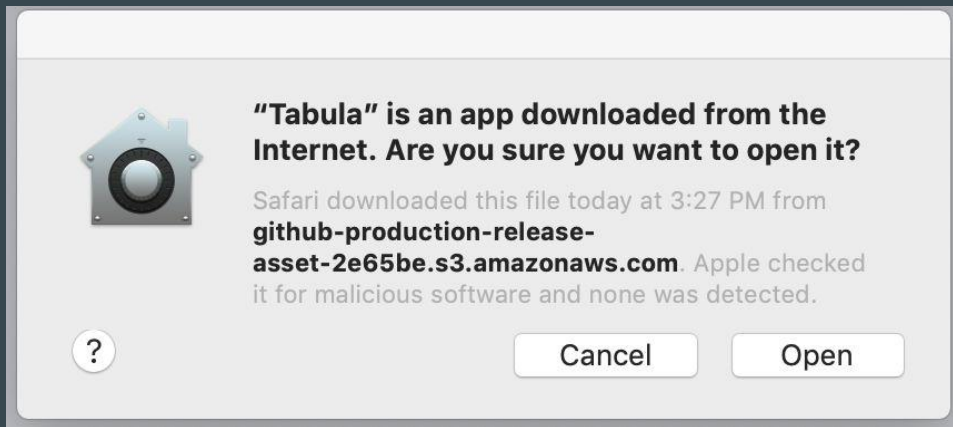
Date	Time	Disposition	Location	Rail Station	Call Type	Disposition Comments
06/17/2024	03:16:00	REPORT	1911 Southern Ave	SOAV	ROBBERY ARMED	ARMED ROBBERY
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06/17/2024	07:34:00	REPORT	730 Kenilworth Ave Ne(295 Side)	MINA	SUBJ WWEAPON	THREATS
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06/17/2024	08:52:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	1101 Howard Rd SE (garage Side)	ANAC	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
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06/17/2024	09:08:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	1101 Howard Rd SE (garage Side)	ANAC	SUBJECT STOP	FTP

Sure looks like a spreadsheet to me!

Setup

Download the latest version for your operating system from <https://tabula.technology/>, then unzip it

and put it in your Applications folder. On a Mac, you may see this warning when launching Tabula for the first time: "Tabula is an app downloaded from the internet. Are you sure you want to open it?" Click Open.



Running Tabula

When you launch Tabula, it will open open

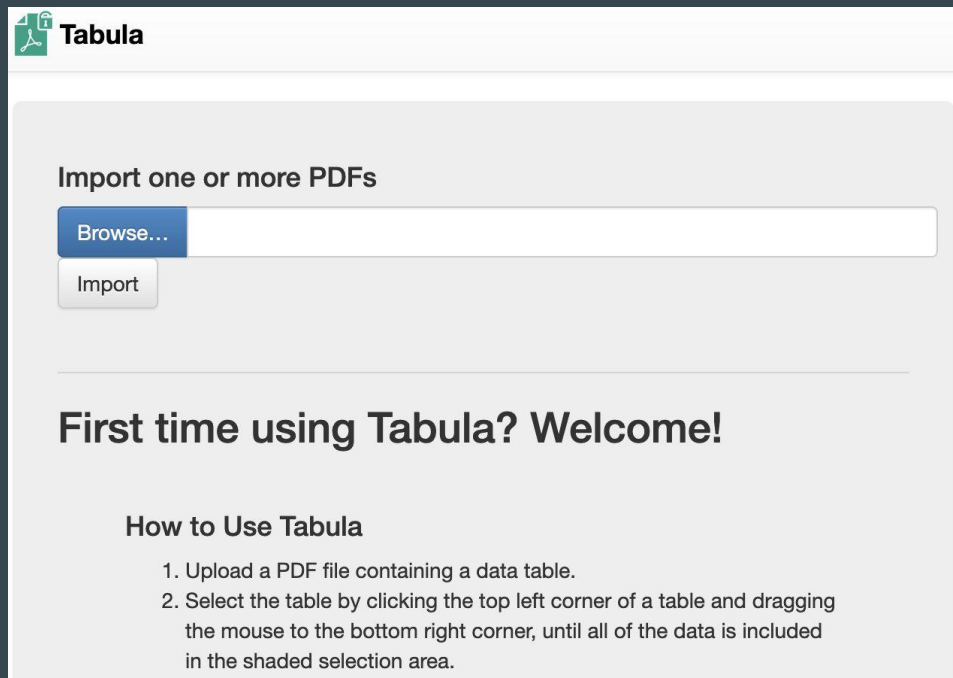
a browser window at

<http://127.0.0.1:8080/>. You might have have

The idea is that you upload a PDF to to hit refresh, but you should see this. Tabula and then can extract data

from tables in it.

Let's upload our PDF:



The screenshot shows the Tabula web application interface. At the top, there is a header with the Tabula logo and name. Below the header, the main content area is titled "Import one or more PDFs". Under this title, there is a "Browse..." button next to a text input field, and an "Import" button below it. A horizontal line separates this section from the next one, which is titled "First time using Tabula? Welcome!". Below this, there is a section titled "How to Use Tabula" containing a numbered list of instructions: 1. Upload a PDF file containing a data table. 2. Select the table by clicking the top left corner of a table and dragging the mouse to the bottom right corner, until all of the data is included in the shaded selection area.

Tabula

Import one or more PDFs

Browse...

Import

First time using Tabula? Welcome!

How to Use Tabula

1. Upload a PDF file containing a data table.
2. Select the table by clicking the top left corner of a table and dragging the mouse to the bottom right corner, until all of the data is included in the shaded selection area.

Check the results

Tabula will take a minute or so to process a PDF, maybe longer depending on your computer.

You'll then get a browser window with pages from the PDF on the left and each page larger on the right.

Tabula

My FilesMy TemplatesAboutHelpSource Code

Support Tabula on OpenCollective!

Blotter-June-19-2026.pdf

TemplatesClear All SelectionsAutodetect Tables

Preview & Export Extracted Data

1

2

3

4



MetroTransit Police

Bus - Rail - Parking Lot - Metro Facilities - Others

Metro Transit Police Blotter



For : Friday, June 19, 2026

Date	Time	Disposition	Location	Rail Station	Call Type	Disposition Comments
06/19/2026	00:11:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	201 Galloway St NE	FTTO	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	00:12:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	201 Galloway St NE	FTTO	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	01:35:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	8400 Coleville Rd	SLS	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	01:37:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	8400 Coleville Rd	SLS	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	02:22:00	ARREST	8400 Coleville Rd (locals)	-	SUBJECT STOP	WARRANT SERVICE, TRESPASSING, THEFT
06/19/2026	03:08:00	ARREST	8400 Coleville Rd	SLS	SUBJECT STOP	OBSTRUCTION
06/19/2026	03:08:00	REPORT	11th St NE / H St NE	-	ASSIST OTHER AGENCY	ASSIST OTHER AGENCY
06/19/2026	06:35:00	ARREST	8th St SE / D St SE	ESTM	DISORDERLY SUBJECTS	DISORDERLY CONDUCT
06/19/2026	07:54:00	REPORT	300 Garnett A. Morgan Blvd	MOBO	UNOCCUPIED VEHICLE	ABANDON VEHICLE
06/19/2026	08:00:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	1101 Howard Rd SE	-	SUBJECT STOP	POCA
06/19/2026	08:05:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	605 7th St NW	GALP	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	08:10:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	201 Galloway St NE	FTTO	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	08:20:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	6638 Richmond Hwy	-	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	08:21:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	605 7th St NW	GALP	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	08:23:00	REPORT	2400 S Smith Blvd	NAPT	INJURED PERSON	INJURED PERSON TO HOSPITAL
06/19/2026	08:27:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	1101 Howard Rd SE	ANAC	SUBJECT STOP	FTP

** Metro Transit Police daily blotter reports show the time and location of arrests, reports and citations for a specified 24-hour period. Generally, reports are published every weekday, except holidays. Please note that blotter reports are not a comprehensive list of every police event, and information is based on initial reports made to MTPD. Follow-up investigations may reveal different or additional information. As a result, the classification of crimes may change as investigations are advanced. Please refer to crime statistics for official information. Incidents that occur aboard trains are reported from the nearest rail station.

Jun 20, 20264:00:00 AM1 of 8Blotter List

Find our table and draw a box around it

Go to page 1, where our table begins, and then using your cursor click and draw a box around the table. Err on the side of more room, not getting it as tight to the border as possible.

If it looks good, click the green “Preview & Export” button.

 MetroTransit Police Bus - Rail - Parking Lot - Metro Facilities - Others Metro Transit Police Blotter 						
For : Friday, June 19, 2026						
Date	Time	Disposition	Location	Rail Station	Call Type	Disposition Comments
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06/19/2026	00:12:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	201 Galloway St NE	FTTO	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
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06/19/2026	01:37:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	8400 Colesville Rd	SLS	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	02:22:00	ARREST	8400 Colesville Rd (local)	-	SUBJECT STOP	WARRANT SERVICE, TRESPASSING, THEFT
06/19/2026	03:08:00	ARREST	8400 Colesville Rd	SLS	SUBJECT STOP	OBSTRUCTION
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06/19/2026	08:16:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	201 Galloway St NE	FTTO	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
06/19/2026	08:20:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	6838 Richmond Hwy	-	SUBJECT STOP	FTP
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Check the results

Depending on how you drew the box, your results might look different from this, but they should be pretty similar.

Tabula has two methods of extraction; you should try them both! When satisfied, hit Export button to get a CSV file.

Blotter-June-19-2026.pdf

Export Format:

CSV

Export

Copy to Clipboard

Preview of Extracted Tabular Data

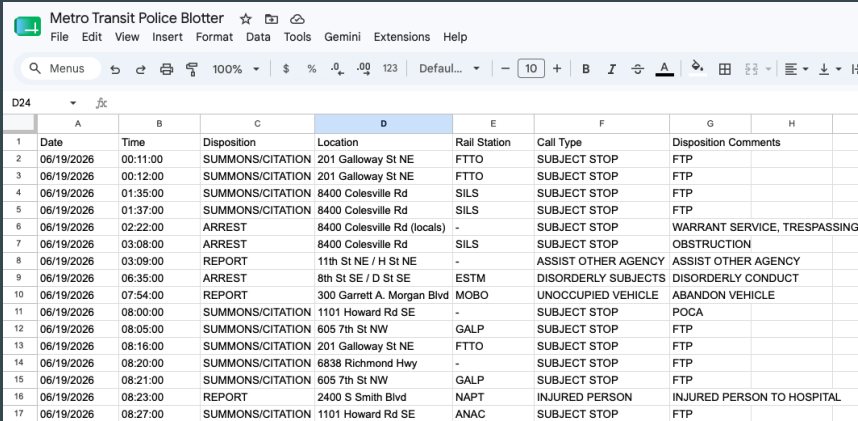
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Exercise

Upload the CSV file into Google Sheets (you can open a new browser window and type **sheet.new** to start. You might

need to clean things up a little bit once you upload the CSV file into Sheets -

some PDFs are worse than others. Here's what mine looks like:



The screenshot shows a Google Sheet titled "Metro Transit Police Blotter". The sheet contains a table with 8 columns: Date, Time, Disposition, Location, Rail Station, Call Type, and Disposition Comments. The data is organized into rows, with the first row (row 1) serving as the header. The table lists various incidents, including summons, citations, arrests, and reports, with details on the date, time, location, and the nature of the incident.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
1	Date	Time	Disposition	Location	Rail Station	Call Type	Disposition Comments	
2	06/19/2026	00:11:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	201 Galloway St NE	FTTO	SUBJECT STOP	FTP	
3	06/19/2026	00:12:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	201 Galloway St NE	FTTO	SUBJECT STOP	FTP	
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15	06/19/2026	08:21:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	605 7th St NW	GALP	SUBJECT STOP	FTP	
16	06/19/2026	08:23:00	REPORT	2400 S Smith Blvd	NAPT	INJURED PERSON	INJURED PERSON TO HOSPITAL	
17	06/19/2026	08:27:00	SUMMONS/CITATION	1101 Howard Rd SE	ANAC	SUBJECT STOP	FTP	

Moar Data!

That first page isn't the only data in the PDF – we can use Tabula to export all of the tables.

Go back and choose “Repeat this Selection”, then “Repeat to All Pages”.

Export and import again.



MetroTransit Police
Bus - Rail - Parking Lot - Metro Facilities - Others
Metro Transit Police Blotter



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Jun 20, 20264:00:00 AM1 of 8Blotter List

Repeat this Selection

Repeat to All Pages

Repeat to Next Page

Now we can ask questions

After removing duplicate header rows, we can make a pivot table to count the call types, for instance. Or the nearest rail station. Or the disposition.

You get the idea. Every dataset can spark multiple questions.

Call Type	COUNTA of Loc
	0
ASSAULT	1
ASSAULTSEXUAL	1
ASSIST PATRON	1
DISORDERLY SUBJECTS	1
EXCHANGE INFORMATION	1
FOLLOW UP	1
PROPERTYDESTRUCTION	2
ROBBERY ARMED	1
SUBJ WWEAPON	1
SUBJECT STOP	51
THEFT	3
TRAFFIC STOP	1
Grand Total	65

What are the stories here?

Also, what if you collected this every day? What if by “you” I meant meant

“a computer”?

What if you automatically got a Slack message summarizing each day’s report and suggesting possible ideas based on the data?

All of that is doable.

Your turn

Pick another PDF and try extracting it into a CSV file like we just did.

Try to add a calculation or pivot table to make it more useful and tell a colleague the best idea or story from it.